A Day for Anne Frank

By C.K. Williams

INTRODUCTION

The number of children murdered during the Nazi genocide may never be known. Some estimates range as high as 1.5 million. Nazi persecution, arrests, and deportations were directed against all members of Jewish families without concern for age. Plucked from their homes and stripped of their childhoods, the children witnessed the murder of parents, siblings, and relatives. They faced starvation, illness and brutal labor, until they were consigned to the gas chambers. Anne Frank was a young girl who was caught up in the horror of the Holocaust and yet in her diary, she wrote the following words ""I simply can't build my hopes on a foundation of confusion, misery and death... I think... peace and tranquility will return again." The following poem by C.K. Williams imagines a scenario for the final days of the famous diarist whose life ended in at the concentration camp Bergen-Belsen. "A Day for Anne Frank" by C.K. Williams

God hates you!

-St. John Chrysostom

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1.

I look onto an alley here

Where, though tough weed and flowers thrust up

through cracks and strain

Toward the dulled sunlight,

There is the usual filth spilling from cans,

The heavy soot shifting in the gutters

People come by mostly

to walk their dogs or to take the shortcut

between the roaring main streets,

Or just to walk

and stare up at the smoky windows,

But this morning when I looked out

Children were there running back and forth

Between the houses toward me.

They were playing with turtles --

Skimming them down the street

Like pennies or flat stones,

And bolting, shouting, after the broken corpses

One had a harmonica, and as he ran,

his cheeks bloating and collapsing like a heart,

I could hear its bleat, and then the girls' screams
suspended behind them with their hair
And all of them: their hard, young breath,
their feet pounding wildly on the pavement to the
corner.

2.
I thought of you at that age,
Little Sister, I thought of you.
Thin as a door,
and of how your thighs would have swelled
and softened like cake,
Your breasts have bleached
and the new hair growing on you like song
would have stiffened and gone dark.
There was rain for a while, and then not.
Because no one came, I slept again,
and dreamed that you were here with me,
Snarled on me like wire,
Tangled so closely to me that we were vines
or underbrush together,

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or hands clenched.

3.
They are cutting babies in half on bets.
The beautiful sergeant has enough money to drink
for a week.
The beautiful lieutenant can't stop betting.
The little boy whimpers
he'll be good.
The beautiful cook is gathering up meat
for the dogs.
The beautiful dogs
love it all.
Their flanks glisten.
They curl up in their warm kennels
and breathe.
They breathe.

4.
Little Sister,
you are a clot

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in the snow,
blackened,
a chunk of phlegm
or puke
And there are men with faces
leaning over you with watercans

watering you!
in the snow, as though flowers would sprout
from your armpits
and genitals.

Little Sister,
I am afraid of the flowers sprouting from you.

I am afraid of the silver petals
that crackle
of the stems darting
in the wind
of the roots.

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5.
The twilight rots.
Over the greasy bridges and factories,
it dissolves
and the clouds swamp in its rose
to nothing.
I think sometimes the slag heaps by the river
should be bodies
and that the pods of moral terror
men make of their flesh should split
and foam their cold, sterile seeds into the tides
like snow
or ash.

6.
Stacks of hair were there
little mountains
the gestapo children must have played in
and made love in and loved
the way children love haystacks or mountains

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Oh, God, the stink
of hair oil and dandruff

Their mothers must have thrown them into their tubs
like puppies and sent them to bed

coming home so filthy stinking

of jew's hair

of gold fillings, of eyelids.

7.
Under me on a roof
a sparrow little by little
is being blown away.
A cage of bone is left,
part of its wings,
a stain.

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8.
And in Germany the street car conductors go to work
in their stiff hats,
depositing workers and housewives
where they belong,
pulling the bell chains,
moving drive levers forward or back.

9.
I am saying goodbye to you before our death. Dear Father: I am saying goodbye to you before my death. We are so anxious to live, but all is lost -- we are not allowed! I am so afraid of this death, because little children are thrown into the graves alive. Goodbye forever.

I kiss you.

10.
Come with me, Anne,
Come,
It is awful not to be anywhere at all,
to have no one

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like an old whore,

a general.

Come sit with me here,

kiss me; my heart is too wounded

with forgiveness.

There is an end now.

Stay.

Your foot hooked through mine

your hand against my hand

your hip touching me lightly.

it will end now

it will not begin again.

Stay

They will pass

and not know us.

the cold brute earth

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is asleep.

there is no danger.

there is nothing,

Anne

there is nothing.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: C.K. Williams
Book: Collected Poems
ISBN: 978-0374530990
Publisher: Macmillan
Date (Month/Year): 2007

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier

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